



BEFORE

The stalemate at Cold Harbor as the two armies faced each other from their trenches grew intolerable for both Grant and Lee.

GRANT LOOKS SOUTH

After [Cold Harbor](#), Grant continued to refine his strategy. He ordered a detachment of Sheridan's cavalry to **destroy the railroads west and southwest of Richmond**, knowing that **Lee's cavalry would set off in pursuit**, leaving him temporarily blind. Grant was **planning an intricate move**, with an eye on the **railroad junction at Petersburg**, 20 miles (32km) south of Richmond and beyond the James River.

PETERSBURG'S DEFENSES

The city was partially protected by formidable fortifications, called the **Dimmock Line**, after military engineer Charles Dimmock, who had directed their construction in 1862. In May, General **P. G. T. Beauregard**, in charge of the city's defenses, had bottled up Butler's Army of the James at **Bermuda Hundred** (see [First Battle of Petersburg](#)). That allowed him to send many of his troops to reinforce Lee, but left him with **scant forces to defend Petersburg** against a surprise attack.

As the night of June 12, 1864 fell on the ravaged fields around Cold Harbor, Union soldiers were quietly on the move. Once well to the rear, they assembled into regiments and then into corps. At dawn, Lee received the astonishing news that the Army of the Potomac had vanished with the night. Grant decided to move against the Confederate supply lines, especially the five railroads intersecting in Petersburg. To do this, he needed to march south and cross the James River, which in places was several miles wide.